London Borough of Camden
Information and Records Management
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Date: 16/11/2020
Ref: CAM676

Dear Requester

Thank you for your request for information dated 26/10/2020 about mowing regime benefit wild flowers. We have dealt with this under the Environmental Information Regulations 2004.

Response

The council holds the information requested and the answers to your questions are as follows:

I would like to know, under Freedom of Information rules, the following:
1. On the road verge network you are responsible for maintaining, are you or your services contractor implementing a mowing regime to benefit wild flowers?
• If yes, can you outline your management practices (e.g. cutting verges later in the year, cutting them less often, collecting the arisings).
• If not, are you or your contractor planning on implementing one from 2021 or beyond?
Works on grass verges managed by Camdens Green Spaces are completed by our Grounds Maintenance term contractor idverde. Mowing regimes are determined on a site by site basis by our Grounds Maintenance team. Currently we have both relaxed mowing and meadow management across some of our grass verges across the borough.

Our relaxed mowing regime includes allowing general amenity grass areas to grow long throughout the year to encourage biodiversity. These areas are cut once per annum and cuttings are collected and removed from site. Camden's meadows are also cut once per annum, however unlike our relaxed mowing areas, these areas are over seeded/plug planted with wildflower.

2. If you or your contractor are implementing such a scheme, what has prompted you to do so (eg. cost savings, reduced CO2 emissions, the impacts of the pandemic)?
What benefits, if any, have you seen? And what, if any, problems have you encountered?
Camden's approach to grounds maintenance is nature conservation led. We will, where practicable, replace high frequency, high cost tasks with more sustainable low maintenance, low costs tasks. Such as replacing general amenity grass cutting with relaxed mowing. This approach is to ensure continual improvements to biodiversity across our green spaces whilst maintaining or reducing costs. This approach has not been influenced by the current pandemic.

3. If you or your contractor have not implemented one, what, if any, reasons are preventing you (eg, safety concerns, lack of information, resident views)?
Implementing relaxed mowing regimes across our boroughs green spaces is an ongoing process which is led by our Grounds Maintenance team. this includes highlighting grass areas where the change can safely be adopted. As previously mentioned, adopting relaxed mowing regimes is determined on a site by site basis. We will only implement such practices were it is feasible and safe to do so.

4. What is your approach to using glyphosate for weed control?
The active ingredient within the product used by our contractor to kill weeds is glyphosate. Our operatives only use the product in response to specific weed growth on hard standings like the pavements, roads and paths that we have an obligation to maintain and keep weed free (the council does not use chemicals for the control of weeds (except Japanese knotweed) in tree bases, flower beds, on lawns, or in nature conservation areas within the borough).

A system called WEED-IT (Weed Economical Eradication Detection – Intelligent Technology) is used and this weed control application technology is mounted on the front of a carrier vehicle. WEED-IT is a computer controlled herbicide application system specifically designed for use on footpaths and other hard surface areas. The system consists of a shrouded spraying head mounted on the front of a purpose-built, articulated carrier vehicle. Within the shrouded head are sensor units and spray nozzles. The sensor units detect the presence of weeds and trigger the appropriate spray nozzles to apply accurately the correct amount of herbicide just to those weeds and their immediate surroundings.

The result is very high levels of weed control coupled with greatly reduced herbicide use and increased safety to the operator and the public. Its use is extremely targeted and controlled, and all operatives using it undergo the requisite training and receive all equipment they need to do the job safely.

Further Information:

We do not give our consent for any names and contact details provided in this response to be sent marketing material. Any such use will be reported to the ICO as a breach of General Data Protection Regulations and the Privacy and Electronic Communication Regulations.

Why not check our Portal Open Data Camden before making a new request as your question may already be answered by a previous FOI response or in one of our many useful and interesting datasets.

Your Rights

If you are not happy with how your response was handled you can request an Internal Review within 2 months of this letter by email to foireviews@camden.gov.uk or post: Information and Records Management Team, London Borough of Camden, Town Hall, Judd Street, London WC1H 9JE. Please quote your case reference number. If you are not satisfied with the Internal Review outcome you can complain to the Information Commissioner's Office at casework@ico.org.uk telephone 0303 123 1113, or post to Information Commissioner's Office, Wycliffe House, Water Lane, Wilmslow, Cheshire, SK9 5AF. The ICO website www.ico.org.uk may be useful.

Yours sincerely

Philip Lewis
Information Rights Officer